

Devender Goud, who has been assigned the task of drafting an alternative economic policy.

There is an urgency to the task. The Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy Government has been in office since May 2004 and fresh elections—not just to the state assembly but also to the Lok Sabha—are less than two years away. He, therefore has to work on two fronts: confabulate with the like-minded parties towards the formulation of an alternative policy for bridging the growing disparity between the rich and the poor, as well as work for the revival of his pet project, the Third Front. The calculation is that such a front will, far from being a hotch-potch alliance, be a formidable centrist alliance that will command greater strength than the Congress and BJP-led alliances in the next Lok Sabha. "Congress has lost ground and will be reduced to a regional party by 2009, while BJP has lost its glory by banking on a communal agenda. This makes it conducive for the regional parties to get together," says the TDP parliamentary party leader, K. Yerranaidu.

Naidu is so confident of returning to power after the next elections that

he has even set out his priorities. "All the welfare and development programmes of the Congress Government, which are named after former prime ministers Indira and Rajiv Gandhi will be scrapped," says Naidu. He is particularly peeved that his successor Rajasekhara Reddy has rejected a proposal to name one of the terminals at the greenfield international airport, which is to open next year, after NTR. He warns that the Congress will have to pay a heavy price for ignoring a charismatic leader like him, whether on the issue of installing his statue in Parliament, awarding him the Bharat Ratna or instituting a national award in his name.

Naidu's problems could well lie in the fact that NTR's family is not ready to concede proprietorial rights over the late chief minister's legacy to him. True, Harikrishna, NTR's fourth son has

already returned to the TDP and his other son, Balakrishna, who is a popular movie actor, is joining TDP's next electoral campaign, giving the party a much needed boost. But there are other equally powerful members in the NTR clan who could turn out to be formidable opponents. D. Purandares-

wari, for instance. She is NTR's second daughter and in this context more importantly, a Congress member and a minister of state for human resources development in the Manmohan Singh Government. She managed to rob some of the sheen off the TDP's silver jubilee party convention when she

described the 25 years celebrations as a "misappropriation of somebody else's dedication, popularity and labour."

She has accused Naidu of "deceiving her father" and asked him to refrain from using his name to "achieve political and personal gains". In a letter

"Congress will be reduced to a regional party by 2009; BJP has lost its glory by banking on a communal agenda"



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